of their Labor party; and Yitzhak Shamir, the Likud leader who had been forced into a power-sharing agreement with Peres after a tight election in 1984.

Before the final part of the ceremony, though, he was eulogized by Netanyahu, President Rivlin, and Knesset speaker Yuli Edelstein; by Clinton and Obama; and by his children. Only the latter (and Rivlin) really tried to eulogize the man himself. The rest of the speeches were political. Some Israelis thought it tasteless—but again, it was hard to imagine Peres, a lifelong political animal, taking offense. His son Yoni, who works as a veterinarian in Tel Aviv, even alluded to his father's priorities in a melancholy passage of his speech. "He decided to dedicate his life to the country and its people," the younger Peres said. "My sister, my brother and I were raised with great devotion by our beloved mother, Sonia."

In his later years, Peres was dedicated most of all to the peace process. Outside of Israel, he is best known for his work on the Oslo Accords, the treaty that gave the Palestinians a degree of autonomy and launched the formal talks about a two-state solution. He shared a Nobel Peace Prize for his efforts, alongside Rabin and Palestinian leader Yasser Arafat. And he continued to work on the issue for the next two decades—even during his stint as president, when Netanyahu's governments had little interest in peace talks.

In the iconic 1993 photos of the Oslo signing ceremony on the White House lawn, Bill Clinton is flanked by four men from the Holy Land: Rabin, Peres, Arafat, and Mahmoud Abbas. Only Abbas is still alive, and the Palestinian president is a spent force, eighty-two years old and deeply unpopular with his own people. It was hard to escape the symbolism of Peres' funeral—a farewell to the man, but also to his great cause. On the Hebrew calendar, ironically, it fell on 27 Elul, twenty-three years to the day after that optimistic moment in Washington.

"Peace is not only possible, it is essential, because we have nowhere to go from here, and the Palestinians also have nowhere to go from here," said Amos Oz, the celebrated Israeli writer who was a longtime friend of the late president. "Where are the brave leaders who will stand up and make these things a reality? Where are Shimon Peres' successors?"

Hawkish man of peace